



BatonIndex

Leadership Succession Intelligence

A RESEARCH BRIEF FOR SEARCH PROFESSIONALS

The Path Before the Deanship

Where business-school deans come from when they come from elsewhere — and why the in-house interim rarely wins.

796

dean appointments

150

Carnegie R1 universities

1990-2025

36 years

A BATONINDEX RESEARCH BRIEF

The Path Before the Deanship

When a business school hires its next dean, the intuitive story is a first-time academic climbing out of the faculty ranks. BatonIndex's population-scale census of 796 dean appointments at all 150 Carnegie R1 universities from 1990 to 2025 tells a different story: nearly half of all outside hires are already sitting or former deans somewhere else, that share has grown sharply over three decades, and the in-house interim who is running the school day to day is, more often than not, passed over for exactly that kind of outside hire.

Six findings

- I The default outside hire is another dean. 49.4% of external hires already hold or held a dean title elsewhere, 38.1 points from a different kind of school, 11.0 points from another business school.
- I The lateral-dean share has nearly doubled. From 35.5% of external hires in the 1990s to 62.2% in the 2020s, a steady, uninterrupted climb every decade.
- I The interim is the underdog for the permanent job. 30.5% of all hires start as interim, but of resolved outcomes only 17.2% convert to permanent in place, while 60.8% are succeeded by an externally recruited sitting or former dean.
- I The most credentialed outside hire has the shortest run. Sitting deans hired laterally from another business school average just 5.3 years in the seat, shorter than any other external-hire type.
- I The industry channel is shrinking as the lateral-dean channel grows. Industry/executive hires fell from 29.0% of external hires in the 1990s to 13.5% in the 2020s, the market is consolidating around academic lateral moves.
- I The lateral-dean channel is not a gendered bottleneck. Women are 25.3% of dean-to-dean lateral hires, slightly above their 22.4% share of external hires overall, unlike the sharp, discipline-specific gaps found elsewhere in this data.

FINDING 1 OF 6**THE DEFAULT OUTSIDE HIRE**

The default outside hire is already a dean

Search committees often frame an external search as a chance to bring in fresh, first-time academic leadership. The record says otherwise: among 344 true external hires (a different university, not a sideways move within the same campus), 49.4% already hold or held the title of dean somewhere else, 38.1 percentage points from a school outside business and 11.0 points from another business school.

Add the next-closest tier, associate or vice deans and department chairs, and roughly three in four external hires already carry a senior academic-leadership title before they walk in the door. First-time faculty-to-dean debuts are the exception among outside hires, not the rule.



Prior position of true-external dean hires (different university); R1 census, 1990-2025.

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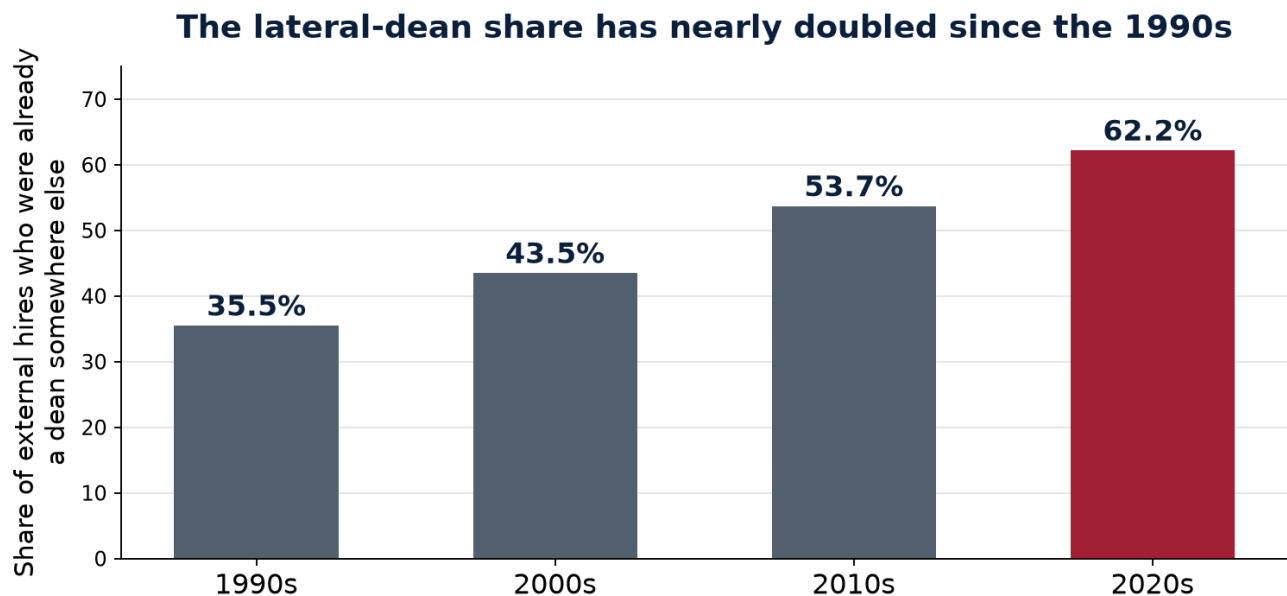
Benchmark a candidate's market value against sitting and former deans, not against the faculty ranks. A "fresh face" external candidate with no prior deanship is competing against a pool where half the field already has the title.

FINDING 2 OF 6**A WIDENING PATTERN**

The lateral-dean market has nearly doubled

This is not a static pattern. The share of external hires who were already a dean elsewhere has climbed every decade on file: 35.5% in the 1990s, 43.5% in the 2000s, 53.7% in the 2010s, and 62.2% so far in the 2020s, a near-doubling in three decades with no reversal.

Recognizable examples run through the whole period: Yash Gupta moved from USC Marshall to Johns Hopkins (2008); George G. Daly from NYU Stern to Georgetown (2005); Sally Blount from NYU Stern to Northwestern Kellogg (2010); Madhav Rajan from Stanford GSB to Chicago Booth (2017); Alexander Triantis from Maryland Smith to Johns Hopkins (2019). A sitting dean's next move is increasingly another deanship.



Share of true-external hires who were already a dean (any kind) elsewhere, by era; R1 census, 1990-2025.

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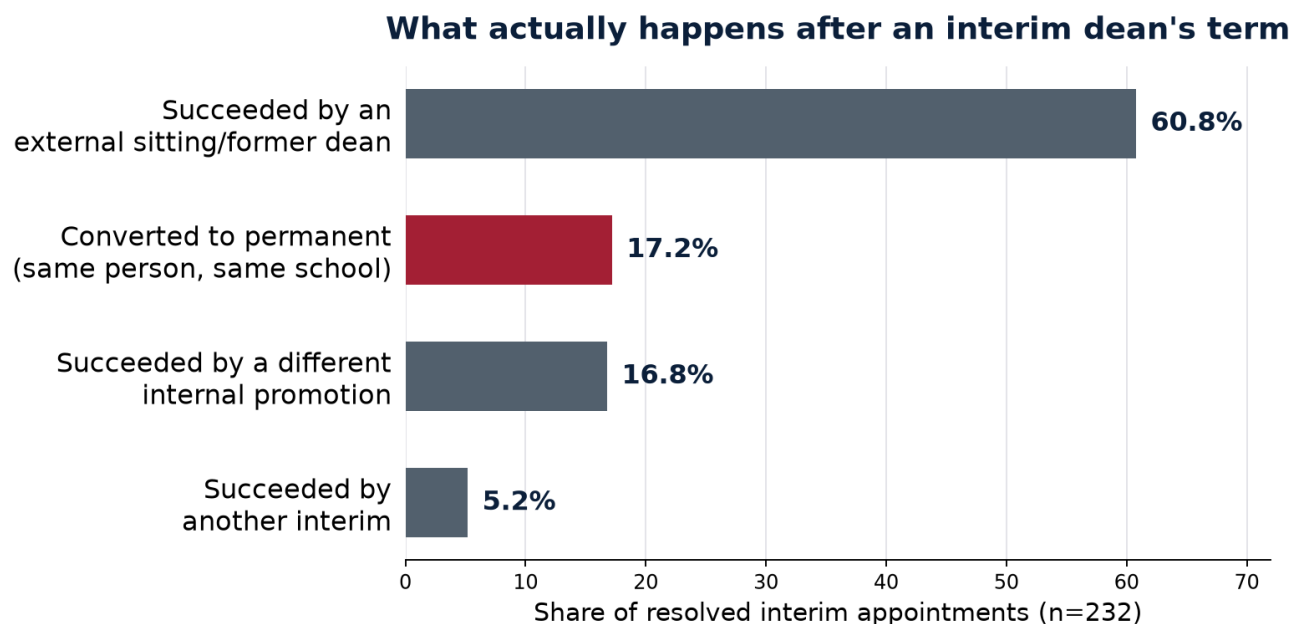
Plan searches assuming the strongest reference set is other sitting or recently departed deans, not associate deans waiting for a first shot. That pool is now the market majority, and it is growing.

FINDING 3 OF 6**INTERIM STEWARDSHIP**

The interim is the underdog for the job

Interim appointments are common, 30.5% of all 796 hires start that way, but the interim seat is not a quiet path to the permanent title. Tracking each interim appointment to its resolved outcome (232 of 243 interim spells with a successor on file), only 17.2% convert to permanent in place. A clear majority, 60.8%, are instead succeeded by an externally recruited sitting or former dean.

The pattern holds at marquee schools: Chicago Booth's interim gave way to Stanford GSB's Madhav Rajan (2017); Northwestern Kellogg's interim to NYU Stern's Sally Blount (2010); MIT Sloan's interim to Wharton's David Schmittlein (2007). The interim more often keeps the seat warm for an outside dean than for themselves.



Outcome of interim dean appointments, resolved cases only; R1 census, 1990-2025.

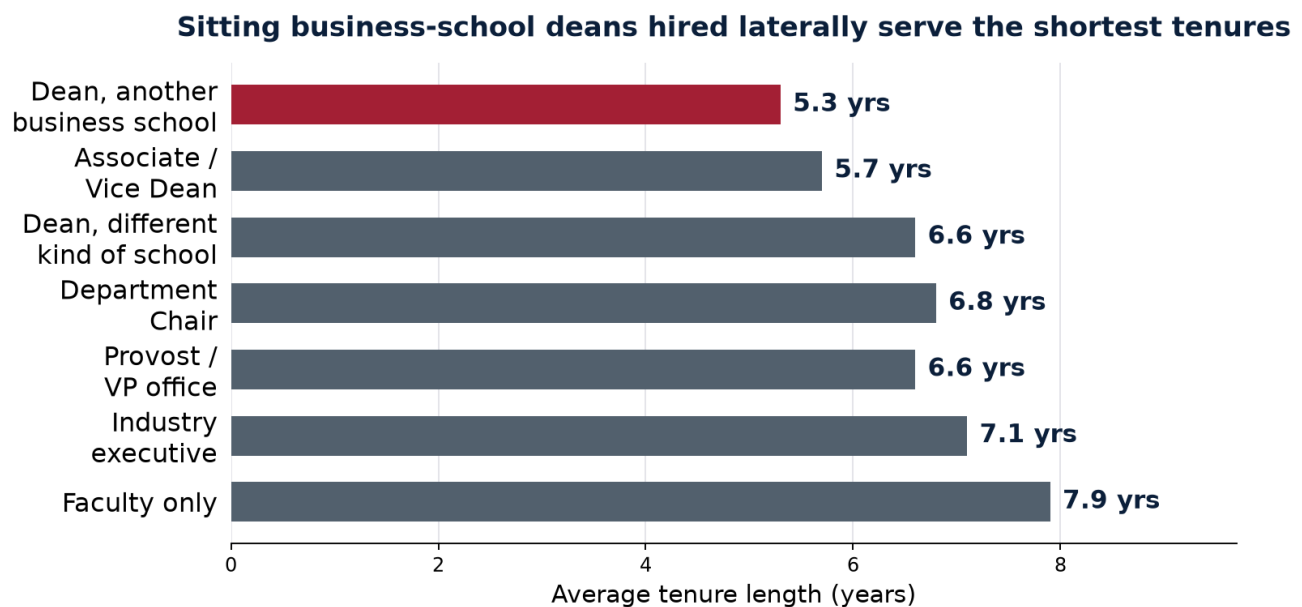
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Don't assume the interim is a lock, or discourage them from competing formally. Run the external search in earnest even with a capable interim in place; the data says the board usually does exactly that.

FINDING 4 OF 6**TENURE OUTCOMES****The most credentialed hire has the shortest run**

Hiring a sitting dean away from another business school is the most visibly credentialed move a search committee can make, and it produces the shortest tenures of any external-hire type on file: 5.3 years on average, versus 6.6 years for a dean recruited from a different kind of school, 6.8 for a department chair, and 7.9 for a faculty-only hire with no prior administrative title.

A plausible reading is that a proven, in-demand business-school dean is also the candidate most likely to be recruited again, by a bigger school, a provost's office, or industry, once installed. The strongest resume is also the most portable one.

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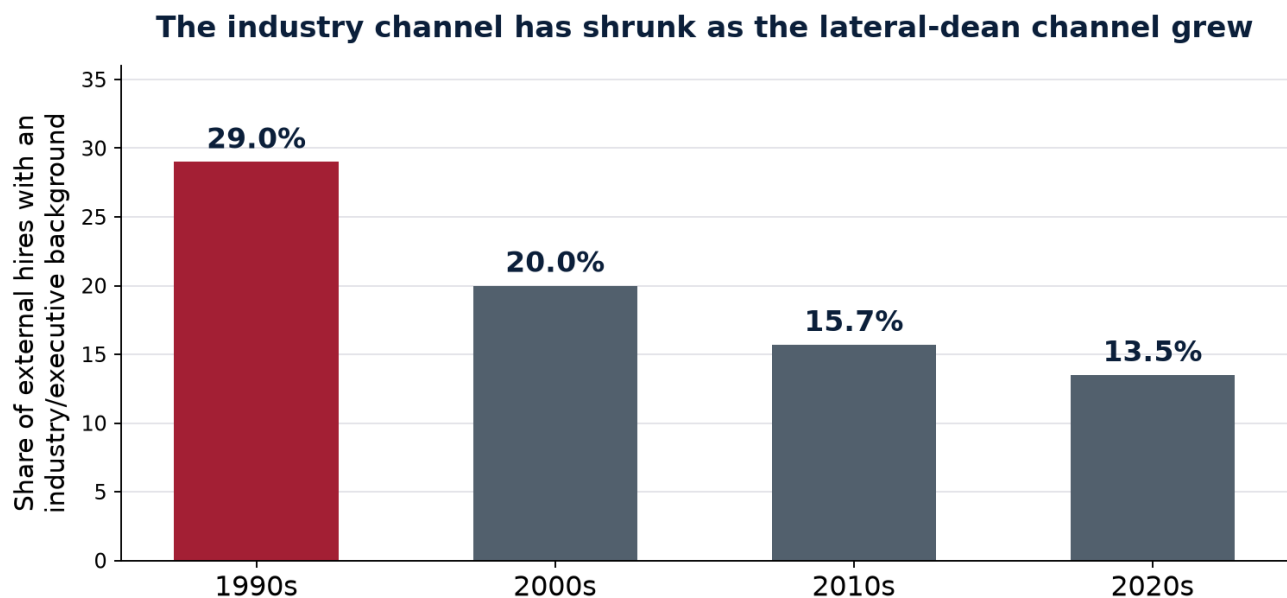
Price the succession-planning cost into a lateral dean-to-dean hire. It is often the fastest, lowest-risk way to fill a seat, but budget for a shorter runway and an earlier next search than a first-time dean hire.

FINDING 5 OF 6**THE SHRINKING ALTERNATIVE**

The industry channel is shrinking as the lateral-dean channel grows

The rise of the lateral-dean hire has a mirror image: the industry-to-deanship channel is fading. Hires with a direct industry or executive background made up 29.0% of external hires in the 1990s; by the 2020s that share had fallen to 13.5%, a steady decline every decade as the academic lateral-dean pool (Finding 2) took a growing share of the same external-hire mix.

The channel has not disappeared, and it still reaches into unexpected places: MIT Sloan's 2025 hire came directly from Apple University, Apple's internal corporate learning arm. But the market is consolidating around academic administrators who have already run a school, not executives making a first crossover into higher education.



Share of true-external hires with an industry/executive background, by era; R1 census, 1990-2025.

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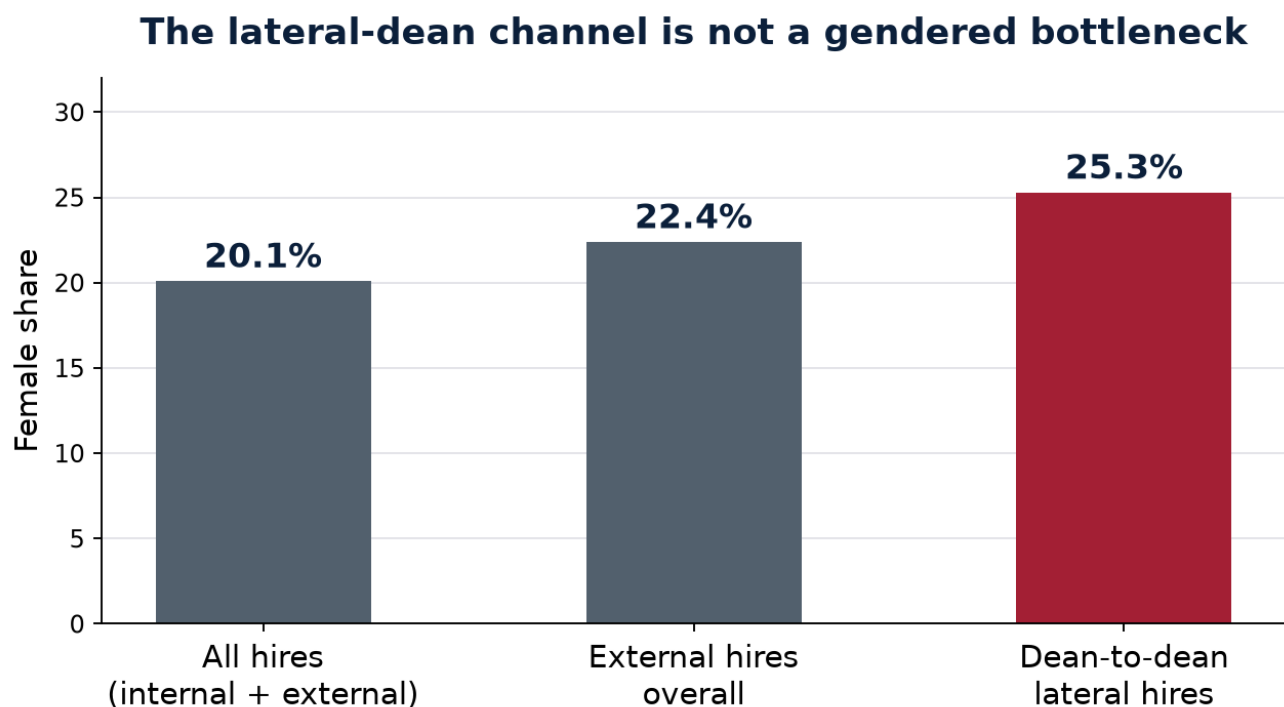
Don't count on the executive-crossover pitch working as well as it once did. If an industry candidate belongs on the slate, frame their case explicitly against a market that increasingly defaults to sitting academic deans.

FINDING 6 OF 6**THE GENDER READ**

The lateral-dean channel is not a gendered bottleneck

BatonIndex's companion brief on gendered pathways found sharp, discipline-specific gaps in who reaches the deanship, worst in operations management. The lateral dean-to-dean channel does not show that same pattern: women are 25.3% of dean-to-dean lateral hires, slightly above their 22.4% share of external hires overall and their 20.1% share of all hires, internal and external combined.

Once a woman has reached a deanship, in other words, the data shows no evidence that she is passed over for the next one at a materially different rate than her male peers. The constraint sits earlier in the pipeline, in who gets the first deanship, not in who gets recruited for the second.



Female share of hires by pool; R1 census, 1990-2025. See "Gendered Pathways in Academic Leadership."

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If the goal is a more representative slate, invest upstream, in the associate-dean and department-chair feeder, not in second-guessing the lateral-dean market, which is not where this particular gap lives.

THE PLAYBOOK

What this means for your next search

Six evidence-based moves for committees and recruiters working the business-school dean market:

- I Default your benchmark to sitting deans. Roughly half of external hires already hold the title; price and reference candidates against that pool, not against first-time academic administrators.
- I Expect the lateral market to keep widening. The dean-to-dean share has climbed every decade since 1990; build sourcing pipelines that assume this year's search draws more sitting-dean interest than last cycle's.
- I Run the outside search even with a strong interim. Only 17% of interims convert to permanent; a credible outside sitting-dean candidate beats the interim more often than not.
- I Budget for a shorter runway on a marquee lateral hire. A dean recruited from another business school serves the shortest average tenure of any external-hire type, plan the next search earlier.
- I Take industry candidates seriously. The channel is a real 12.5% of external hires with tenure on par with academic hires, not a symbolic or risky outlier pick.
- I Put the gender work upstream. The lateral dean-to-dean channel itself is not where the representation gap lives; invest in the associate-dean and department-chair feeder instead.

METHODOLOGY & ABOUT

About this brief

This brief draws on the same BatonIndex census used in "The Discipline Behind the Dean" and "Gendered Pathways in Academic Leadership": a hand-coded, web-verified record of 796 dean appointments at all 150 Carnegie R1 universities, 1990-2025. Each appointment is classified by origin (internal, external, or a same-university move to a different school), prior title and institution, and appointment type (permanent or interim).

Prior-position categories were assigned from each dean's recorded prior title and institution (dean, associate/vice dean, department chair, provost/VP office, faculty-only, or an industry/executive background). Interim outcomes were determined by matching each interim appointment to the next appointment on file at the same school: a same-person match with no further interim tag counts as "converted to permanent"; a different, externally sourced successor counts as "succeeded by an external hire." Interim spells with no successor yet on file (the school's most recent appointment) are excluded from the resolved-outcome figures in Finding 3.

Appointments were assembled from primary sources, university announcements, official biographies and CVs, and contemporaneous coverage, and passed a full web-verification pass in 2026.

BatonIndex maintains leadership-succession intelligence on more than 10,000 academic leaders across twelve role families, business, medical, law, nursing, pharmacy, education, agriculture, public health, arts & sciences deans, provosts, and presidents, with sourced education histories, career pathways, and live appointment tracking. This brief is one view into that data.

PUT THE DATA TO WORK

Want the underlying benchmarks for a specific school, discipline, or region, or a co-branded edition of this brief for a client? Reach the BatonIndex team through the Contact link in the app.

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